> In a porch leading by a wide staircase to the rampart I found between 30 and 40 bodies lying together, many of them on fire and partially burnt . . . Some affecting scenes took place in removing the bodies. The party who had taken a corpse from a house found it dragged back immediately their backs were turned and a woman and child crying over it. Every house and shop was ransacked and scarce a household remained unstained by blood. Between 500 and 600 bodies were counted into pits and the probability is that not less than 1000 were killed altogether. The wounded were in a sad plight and were to be seen for the remainder of our stay in the town . . . some burnt, some with gunshot and bayonet wounds, others with shattered limbs and thirteen even blown up in one explosion at a Gun. The Governor of the Fort, Dost Mahomed's son Hyder Khan, was discovered in a tower over a gateway and gave up his sword on being promised his life.[96]

By nine in the morning, resistance was at an end. It was now time for the prize agents to begin systematically collecting the loot which would be shared among the troops. It took five days to cart everything out, according to Mirza 'Ata. They removed 'to their own godown 3,000 horses of Turkish, Arabian and Iranian breed; 2,000 camels from Kabul, Balkh, Bukhara and Baghdad; sword hilts from Isfahan and Tehran in Iran; hundreds of pashmina shawls from Kashmir; thousands of maunds of raisins, almonds, salted pistachios, clarified butter, rice, flour; thousands of pistols'. The scholarly Mirza 'Ata was especially interested in a part of the booty which no British source seems to have noted: the Kandahar palace library – 'Several thousand precious and unique books in Persian and Arabic, covering all the sciences, logic, literary criticism, principles of jurisprudence, syntax and grammar'.[97]

It was a spectacular victory: the impregnable fortress of Ghazni had been captured within seventy-two hours of the army first sighting it. As well as a thousand fatalities, around 300 Afghans were wounded and 1,500 taken prisoner. In contrast, the British suffered only seventeen killed with around sixty-five wounded.[98] But, as Durand later pointed out, the success of the assault was largely due to luck, as by leaving behind the siege guns and marching without sufficient supplies Keane had 'committed a grievous military error; but as if in mockery of human prudence and foresight, war occasionally affords instances in which a mistake becomes, under the inscrutable will of Providence, the immediate cause of brilliant and startling success: and such this error ultimately proved'.[99]

If the British had won a remarkable victory against the odds, the Afghans had hardly disgraced themselves. They had shown their fighting skills, and the bravery of the defenders, even when all was lost, created legends that